

THE MEDIA BUSINESS

THE MEDIA BUSINESS; The Marketing of a Cause Célèbre

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Nov. 16, 1992



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Donna Tartt's first novel, "The Secret History," the story of a group of classics students at a New England college who become involved in one ritualistic Dionysian murder and another murder to cover their tracks, was a cause celebre way before it was a best seller.

Ms. Tartt's agent is Amanda Urban of International Creative Management, one of the most powerful literary representatives; her publisher is Sonny Mehta, head of Alfred A. Knopf, and her editor is Gary Fisketjon -- the "Tinker to Evans to Chance" axis in the publishing world.

To top it off, Ms. Tartt was introduced to the high-profile three by Bret Easton Ellis, one of the original brat-pack authors of the 1980's who published several books to a loud chorus of not always favorable attention.

So when word about Ms. Tartt's book, which she worked on for eight years, first started circulating, cynics in the publishing world turned on their doubt meters. Another twentysomething wonder, they snipped. Skepticism to Applause

Then copies of the novel started getting around, and the skepticism began to subside. Applauding reviews squashed most remaining doubts and several months on a host of best-seller lists established "The Secret History" as a true commercial and critical success.

How the novel became such an all-round triumph is a case of the best of marketing and promotion meeting the best of writing, the complementing of strategy and talent.

Although it sounds self-serving when editors and publicists at Knopf say that the book succeeded on its merits, booksellers and editors of best-seller lists agreed, and many said in interviews, that "The Secret History" kept its best-selling

position for months not only because of brilliant marketing but because it was a wonderful piece of fiction praised by critics and through word of mouth.

But the booksellers and people at the publishing house also allow that many worthy books do not achieve the sales and visibility of "The Secret History," and that other factors were put into place that helped to bring Ms. Tartt's book the kind of attention that generates sales.

"We as publishers can only influence events in a limited way," Mr. Mehta said. "To the extent that we were able, we did everything right and nothing wrong."

There was also some "gratuitous fortune," as Mr. Mehta put it, or what others would call dumb luck. 'A Distinctive Look'

Knopf bought the book a few days before the 1991 American Booksellers Convention, which was held that year in New York City. People familiar with the negotiations said the publisher paid about \$450,000 for the book, which was the highest offer Ms. Urban received, and paperback rights were sold for about \$500,000 more to Ivy. In quick order, Alan J. Pakula bought the movie rights.

Since there had been a heated auction for the book, which was then being called "The God of Illusions," it naturally became one of the talked-about titles at the annual gathering of bookstore owners and managers.

"There's no doubt that getting a buzz going at the A.B.A. in New York was important," said Paul Bogaards, Knopf's promotion manager, who orchestrated Ms. Tartt's publicity.

The next step was the look of the book. The book's packaging was carefully created by Knopf's design department "to allow it to be as distinctive as possible," Mr. Mehta said. It is narrower and longer than most novels, and part of the cover, which features a closeup of a classic statue, is printed on an acetate jacket.

A year later, when the booksellers met in Anaheim, Calif., for their annual convention, Knopf had prepared handsome advance readers' editions of the book with its new title, "The Secret History," which it distributed generously. This paperback of the bound galleys foreshadowed the unusual size and cover of the novel. More importantly, it kept talk of the book alive.

"The idea was to get the book to as many people as possible," Mr. Mehta said.

The move would probably have backfired if the booksellers felt the book did not live up to the attention the publisher was giving it. But the booksellers' enthusiasm encouraged Mr. Bogaards to schedule a 15-city reading tour for Ms. Tartt before any of the praiseworthy reviews appeared.

Mr. Mehta said he also coordinated the publication date of the book to give Ms. Tartt maximum opportunities for reviews and articles. He chose early September, he said, before the traditional mid-fall release of big-name best-selling authors. Promotion Efforts

The next step was to get readers wondering about the book. For that, it was important to have articles or small mentions of the book in magazines and even gossip columns.

"So when Tina Brown leaned across the lunch table in July and asked what was hot, I said Donna Tartt," Ms. Urban said.

At the time, Ms. Brown, now the editor of The New Yorker, was the editor in chief of Vanity Fair. A lengthy profile of Ms. Tartt, including trips to her native Mississippi and to her alma mater, Bennington College in Vermont, ran in Vanity Fair in September.

Mr. Mehta also understood that a novel that is "enthralling" and "remarkably powerful" (which is how Michiko Kakutani described it in a review in The New York Times) is only helped by an author who is bright, attractive, articulate and well read. Ms. Tartt cuts a charming and sophisticated figure at interviews. She

arrived at one in a tailored scarlet jacket with faux leopard collar, cuffs and gloves, and lipstick deep as the waistcoat punctuating her pale face, and she steadily quoted literary works that ranged from "The Iliad" to "The Wizard of Oz."

"We didn't know what she looked like when we bought the book," said Mr. Mehta, "but it certainly hasn't hurt."

Articles of varying lengths, most with sassy pictures of Ms. Tartt, landed like a coordinated storm in the September issues of many magazines, including Esquire, Mirabella, M, Cosmopolitan, Glamour and Elle.

"In publishing, it is sometimes hard to draw the line where good publicity turns into hype," said Mr. Fisketjon, her editor. "But not everything that got said or written about the book was in our control. It's like a pinball machine. You hit the ball out there once, and then it jumps around and lights up the machine on its own. It's not exactly beyond our control, but it's not necessarily stuff we specifically generated." Hype Machine in Overdrive?

But the slew of publicity, before the novel was in the stores or had been reviewed, caused some murmuring about a hype machine in overdrive. People at Knopf suddenly became overprotective of Ms. Tartt and in speaking about how the book was promoted, everyone involved with it is careful to say that the book's best publicity was the book itself.

Mr. Fisketjon described heavy publicity, in general, as having "a loaded gun pointed at you." But he conceded that no matter how skeptical or snide or even nasty publicity can be, "it's basically a no-lose situation for any book."

"If the book's not that great," he said, "you figure the publicity is good because the book's probably not going to get anywhere on its own, and at least the publicity brings it some notice. And when you really know you've got a great book, like Donna's, it will pay off for people after they pick it up."

A correction was made on Nov. 24, 1992: An article on the Media Business page on Nov. 16, about the marketing of Donna Tartt's novel "The Secret History," referred incorrectly to a player in the Chicago Cubs' formidable double-play combination of the early 1900's. It was Johnny Evers (not Evans) who was the second baseman in "Tinker to Evers to Chance."

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A version of this article appears in print on , Section D, Page 6 of the National edition with the headline: THE MEDIA BUSINESS; The Marketing of a Cause Celebre